The Design Loop: Free Guide

🎯 **Claude Design has taste. It just can't judge its own work.**

The context that builds a piece is the context that grades it — a chef reviewing their own restaurant. Five stars, every time. The Design Loop fixes exactly that: it moves the judging into **fresh contexts** that never saw the work being made.

Parallel agents buy you speed. *Fresh context buys you the result.*

Source of the Gauntlet loop

This method is an adaptation of the **Gauntlet Loop**, invented by **Matt Shumer**. He named it, defined it, and built the original — a Three.js FPS from a single prompt that did 3.8M views. Everything on this page is a variation on his idea.

Matt Shumer introduces the Gauntlet Loop

- His founding post — "I'm officially calling this the Gauntlet Loop"
- How to run one, and why it works for more than games
- The original prompt, verbatim (GitHub)
- The method write-up

Start here

1. Export your system

In **Claude Design**, ask it to write out your design system as a single `design-system.md`. Do this **once** per project.

2. Install the skill

Drop `SKILL.md` into `.claude/skills/design-loop/` in your project. Claude Code reads it automatically.

3. Run it

Type `/design-loop` and answer three questions. That's it — you type twice in the whole run.

⚠️ **Reserve this for your hero asset.** Every round is a build plus three judgments. It is genuinely token-hungry. Use it on the landing page or the flagship carousel — not on the whole site. Your weekly limit is the real hard stop, and **you are the brake**.

The skill

The whole thing is one file. Save it as `.claude/skills/design-loop/SKILL.md` inside your project, then type `/design-loop`.

```
> Loading Markdown code…
```

The three critics

You never write a critic. The three roles are hardcoded so they never converge into the same opinion — but each one's specific brief is written per run, because "does it hit the brief" means something different for an animation than for a pricing page.

Critic	Judges against	Model	Why
Brief	The stated goal only, ignoring aesthetics	Sonnet	Simple judgment, no vision needed
System	`design-system.md` only	Haiku	Mechanical adherence checking
Craft	`bar.md` and rendered frames, never the code	Strongest available	**Never downgrade this one.** A cheap craft critic approves everything and the loop dies on round one.

What makes a bar actually work

The teardown converts your reference into **mechanisms a critic can check by looking**. This is the step that does the real work, and it is also the step people get wrong. Adjectives are unfalsifiable; measurements are not.

❌ **Useless**

- Feels premium

✅ **Checkable**

- Headline is 5x body size

- Clean and modern
- Good use of whitespace
- Strong visual hierarchy

- Three type sizes total, no more
- One accent colour, max twice per screen
- Nothing animates under 400ms

A vague bar is the single most common reason this fails. The critic invents its own comparison and approves everything on round one.

Cost, honestly

The cost line inside any prompt is a **wish, not a brake** — the model can't reliably see its own spend. Here's a real, publicly reported number from someone running this method to build an F1 game from a single prompt:

19 hrs	1.7B	137	~$1,200
one run	tokens	agents	API cost

That is the extreme end — a 19-hour game build, not a landing page. But it's the honest shape of the trade: **this is powerful because it's expensive.** Real controls, in order of what actually works:

1. Watch it and stop it. You are the brake.
2. Cap the **pieces** to three or four, not the rounds. Every extra piece multiplies the run.
3. Let your weekly limit be the hard stop.

What this version adds

Addition	Why it matters
A **teardown pass** into `bar.md`	Converts a reference into checkable mechanisms *before* any building starts
Three critics with distinct briefs	Each can fail work the other two would pass — one "harsh critic" collapses into a single opinion
A **preflight** check	Verifies the critic can actually see before you waste a whole run
Model tiering across critics	Cheap where judgment is mechanical, strongest where it's taste

🧠 **The one thing to remember**

A critic that shares memory with the builder is grading its own homework. Everything else here is detail.